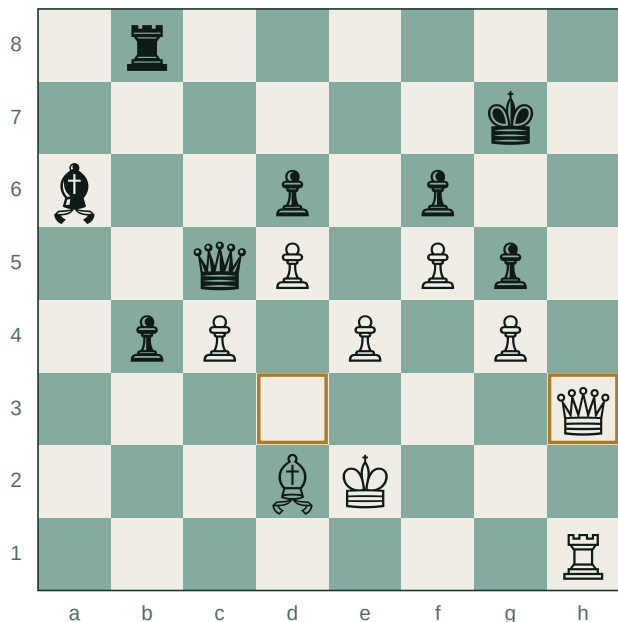


Exposed-king tactics: Black, move 38

Exposed-king tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 38.Qh3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

38...Qxc4+ 39. Kf2 Qe2+ 40. Kg1 Qd1+

38...Qxc4+ Check restricts White to 6 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on c4. Recorded reply: **39.Kf2**.

39...Qe2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. From e2 it attacks king on f2 and bishop on d2. Recorded reply: **40.Kg1**.

40...Qd1+ Check restricts White to 5 legal replies here. From d1 it attacks king on g1 and bishop on d2.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 21 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +1: the balance goes from -1 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on e2. Absolute pin: pawn on c4.